

Four marks walked, four places named – and at the end of the chain, where your contact should be standing, no one. Only a sealed packet, left where you could not miss it, a hand you half-recognise scrawled on the outside; and folded inside, a single scrap of paper. He is gone. Fled, or taken, or thinking better of the whole thing – but gone. A contact who vanishes the very night the city takes up arms is rarely one who simply chose to leave.

You had heard the city all the way here. Saint Dorothy's crowds parting for carts the carters swear are loaded with fireworks "for the feast" – yet the crates ride low and heavy, and the men walking beside them are not laughing. And under the masks the same talk keeps surfacing, again and again, if you let yourselves listen: that the Council meets after dark and decides for everyone and tells no one, because it fears the light. That it is the craftsmen who give up the men and the steel, and the Council that will still be ruling once the smoke clears – not them. That war means bread at double the price, a lords' quarrel paid for at the baker's stall. That Bażyński means to hand Prussia to the king in Kraków – one master traded for another – and that some knight or other will walk off with the whole of it in his pocket once the towns have done the dying. And, from an old woman who shook her head as you passed: that this Bażyński's own leg has gone stiff on him again, that the great man can barely cross a room – and that this is who means to bring down armoured knights.

The letter is still heavy in the bag, and it still has to reach the one it is meant for before the eighth bell. With your contact gone, the way is yours to find. You unfold his scrap – and beside it the packet has left you something to work from: three people sent into town this morning, and the errands they ran.

THE MORNING ERRANDS

Three people went into town this morning, and each bought one thing.

Work out who bought what – and where each of them works.

Where they work, what is made there – and the mark each place bears on your map:

- The Old Mill – bread – +
- Piccolo – hot food (*a kitchen – ladled out*) – ≡
- The Smithy – ironwork – ⊥

The three: Kordian · Lambert · Jordan *What each one bought:* food · a sword · cloth

Heard about town this morning – every word of it true:

1. Lambert could have eaten at his own place, yet he went to buy his food elsewhere.
2. Jordan bought from the one who bought cloth.
3. The miller swears he bought nothing from Kordian.

Place all three, and for each you will have a name, a trade, and the mark their workplace bears. ONLY ONE OF THOSE THREE MARKS IS ON YOUR MAP. THAT IS THE DOOR YOU GO TO – AND NO OTHER.

So you are on your own. A puzzle to point you at a door, a stranger behind it to point you onward, and the letter still heavy in the bag. Whoever R₂ was, he is gone – you are not. Three people, three errands. Work it out.